

Inference Skills — Part 1

Name: _____

Date: _____

Time: 15 min

1 · COPY THIS DOWN — WHAT INFERENCE ACTUALLY IS

DEFINITION

An **inference** is a sensible conclusion you reach by combining what the passage *directly says* with your own reasoning — it is not stated outright, and it is not a wild guess either. Every inference must be traceable back to real evidence in the text.

THE TECHNIQUE

EVIDENCE + REASONING = INFERENCE

1. **Evidence:** find the exact detail in the passage (an action, a word choice, something said or not said)
2. **Reasoning:** ask "what would this detail normally mean, or what does it usually suggest?"
3. **Inference:** combine both into one full sentence — never answer with just the evidence, and never answer with just your reasoning alone

Watch for these question phrases — they are always asking for inference, not a quote: "What does this suggest...", "We can infer that...", "How does X feel...", "What is implied by..."

2 · WORKED EXAMPLE

"Anwen read the letter twice, then folded it back along its original creases and put it in the drawer she never opened."

EVIDENCE reads it twice; folds it along the *original* creases (careful, precise); puts it in a drawer she "never opened"

REASONING Reading something twice suggests it matters or is hard to process. Being careful to refold it exactly, and hiding it somewhere untouched, suggests she wants to preserve it but not have to face it again.

INFERENCE Anwen is emotionally affected by the letter's contents and wants to keep it safe without confronting it again soon — this suggests the letter is upsetting or significant to her, not neutral news.

3 · PRACTICE PASSAGE

1 Mr. Okonkwo checked his watch for the third time in as many minutes, then stood and walked to the classroom door, looking down the corridor before sitting back down. He picked up his pen, put it down again without writing anything, and straightened a stack of papers that was already straight.

2 When the door finally opened, it wasn't the person he seemed to be expecting — just the caretaker, asking about the broken radiator. Mr. Okonkwo answered him politely enough, but his eyes kept drifting back to

the doorway even after the caretaker had left.

1. Using the evidence + reasoning method, what can we infer about how Mr. Okonkwo is feeling in paragraph 1? Show your evidence and reasoning separately before giving your final inference.

2. What does straightening "a stack of papers that was already straight" suggest about Mr. Okonkwo, beyond the literal action?

3. After the caretaker leaves, what can we infer from the detail that "his eyes kept drifting back to the doorway"?

4. Is it reasonable to infer that Mr. Okonkwo was expecting the caretaker specifically? Explain your answer using evidence from the passage.

Apply this every time: Never answer an inference question with only a quote, and never answer with only your opinion. Always show both: the evidence, and the reasoning that connects it to your conclusion.

MARKING NOTES (FOR THE TUTOR)

1. **Q1:** Evidence: checking watch repeatedly, going to the door, unable to focus on writing. Reasoning: these are all signs of restlessness/anxiety while waiting. Inference: Mr. Okonkwo is anxiously waiting for someone or something to arrive.
2. **Q2:** A nervous, fidgeting habit — doing something with his hands to manage anxious energy, not because the papers actually needed straightening.
3. **Q3:** He is still waiting/expecting someone else — the caretaker wasn't who he was hoping for, and his attention returns to the door.
4. **Q4:** No — the passage states the caretaker "wasn't who he seemed to be expecting," directly contradicting that inference. Reward answers that use this evidence correctly to reject the inference.